

LI Zhimin's Short Talk on the Event:

Spirit of Poetry for Maturation of Modern Civilization

In May of 2001, I was invited to read a poem at the Cambridge Conference of Contemporary Poetry (CCCCP). I sent the poem entitled as “A Love of the Shining Night” to Mr. J.H. Prynne for advice, who commented that “It is a dramatic piece, maybe even apocalyptic.” Indeed, “A Love of the Shining Night” was of my deep concern and worries about the fate of humanity. I don't know why I felt, and still feel, the threat of nuclear weapons, environmental pollution and many others that could extinguish humanity so acutely, much more acutely than most people I know.

This year, before coming over to Cambridge in January, I reread the poem “A Love of the Shining Night” and found the situation of humanity had not been improved in the past two decades. On the contrary, with the outbreak of the War of Ukraine in 2022, the fast development of AI in recent years, the ever more turbulent political and economic clashes and many more problems occurring, the situation has been much worsened. Despite the fact that people are often consciously or subconsciously assuming that humanity is making progress with the development of modern science and technology that is the driving force of modern civilization, I feel that the situation for the survival of humanity is deteriorating fast.

I firmly believe that something must be done to realign the trend that has been developing ever since the start of the modern age of humanity because the modern civilization we are now in is far from its maturity since the very survival of humanity is endangered with the development of modern societies. In the mechanism of the current modern civilization, the more developed the societies are, the more endangered the very survival of humanity is.

Only after the very survival of humanity could be absolutely ensured, we can enter into the mature phase of modern civilization, so that we could enjoy the benefits brought about by the development of modern science and technology, without worrying that the whole of humanity might be wiped out by a crazy person who pushes a button to launch a nuclear war or who puts some evil codes into an AI program that could kill all humanity.

I believe the path for human beings to enter into the mature phase of modern civilization can be found in the field of humanity and arts, especially poetry, that produces such noble qualities as understanding, kindness and love among all human beings.

I have found that many people I know, such as many of my friends at Cambridge, have such noble qualities. For example, Mr. J.H. Prynne was very kind to me and gave me many hours of free supervision when I was a visiting PhD student here from 2001 to 2002. Mr. J.H. Prynne introduced me to Dr. Richard Gooder who kindly guided me in running a journal in English entitled as *EPSIANS*, a poetry journal published in China. I was born in China, and was brought up in China. However, it seems there is no problem at all for me to identify and appreciate all the noble qualities of people all around the world. Indeed, all human beings share very similar understanding of the noble qualities of human beings that are the best to unite peoples all over the world and to guide humanity into the mature phase of modern civilization.

I believe every human being is born with such noble qualities that are the spirit of humanity, though the noble qualities are fully awoken in some people, while not so in others. The mechanism of the communication between people whose noble qualities have been woken up is like that of the Quantum Entanglement, which enables people to well understand each other, treat each other kindly, and love each other wholeheartedly. As a result, humanity could truly cooperate with each other, and

humanity as a whole could enter into the mature phase of modern civilization.

The spirit of poetry lies in the spirit, i.e., the noble qualities of human beings. With such a spirit, poetry is an ideal means to awaken and strengthen people's faith in the noble qualities. Before coming over to Cambridge in January, I thought of paying a visit to Dr. Richard Gooder's grave to pay my respect to him. However, after arriving at Cambridge, I heard that Dr. Gooder had his ashes scattered in the garden of Clare College, which is one of the loveliest places in Cambridge, so that I decided to organize a poetry reading event to have a dialogue in spirit with Dr. Gooder. Either the spirit of human beings or the spirit of poetry never dies. Therefore, I believe Dr. Gooder is with us, somewhere in the garden, and is having a spiritual communication with us in the way of the Quantum Entanglement. In the spiritual world, to believe something is a fact. When we believe it, it takes place instantly.

Poetry does make something happen. It makes something happen deep in our souls, in the spiritual world of human beings. We should not say that poetry makes nothing happen just because we could not see it happening.

I will begin by reading a poem dedicated to Dr. Richard Gooder. It is the 18th sonnet of William Shakespeare.

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